

CONSPIRACY THEORY

Security agencies had information on SIMI which could have nabbed the perpetrators of the Jaipur and Ahmedabad blasts before they struck. Was this a colossal intelligence failure?

■ By Sandeep Unnithan

In the run up to the 9/11, the US intelligence received myriad warnings of impending terrorist attacks against the country. No one collated the intelligence inputs. When the dust had settled on the rubble of the twin towers, the realisation of a colossal intelligence failure began to sink in. The arrest of Students Islamic Movement of India (SIMI) chief Safdar Nagori and 12 key associates near Indore on March

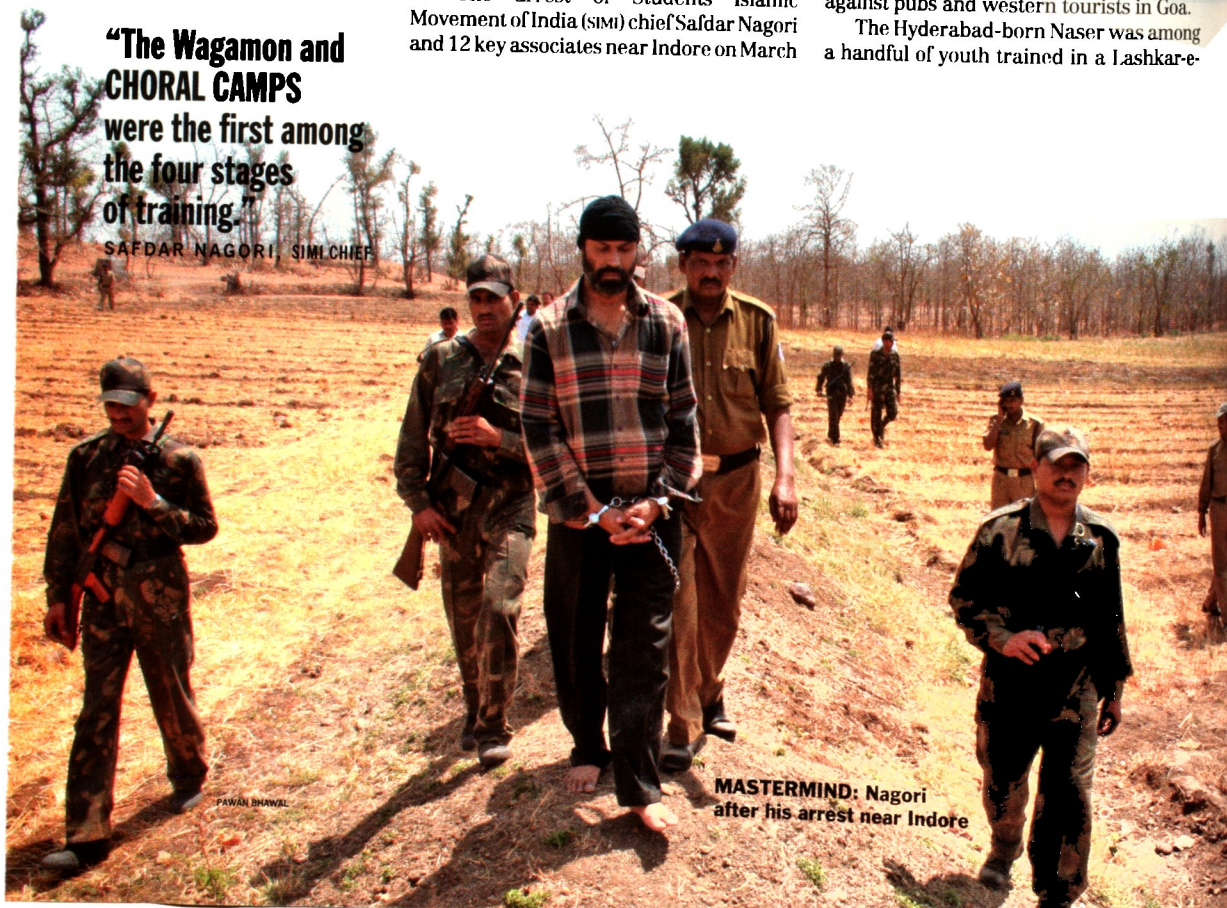
26 this year yielded an exhaustive insight into a shadowy radical organisation about which little was known after it had been banned in September 2002. The organisation had split into a still more radical Islamic Movement (the police believe this to be an alias for the Indian Mujahideen which carried out the Jaipur and Ahmedabad blasts). Led by the charismatic 38-year-old Nagori, the Islamic Movement (IM) had Pakistan-trained youth—bomb makers and computer experts in their midst who held training camps in Gujarat, Kerala and Karnataka to prepare its cadre for larger operations. Yet, the entire module had been uprooted. Or was it? Did these arrests and subsequent debriefs—months before the bicycle bombs wrought havoc in Jaipur and Ahmedabad—lull the police into complacency?

It all began in the sleepy town of Honnali in Davangere, northern Karnataka, in the wee hours of January 11 when local police arrested Raziuddin Naser, 24, and Asadullah Abubakar, a medical student in Hospet in Karnataka, for riding a stolen motorcycle. The duo was on a reconnaissance mission for possible Bali-style attack against pubs and western tourists in Goa.

The Hyderabad-born Naser was among a handful of youth trained in a Lashkar-e-

"The Wagamon and CHORAL CAMPS were the first among the four stages of training."

SAFDAR NAGORI, SIMI CHIEF



MASTERMIND: Nagori after his arrest near Indore